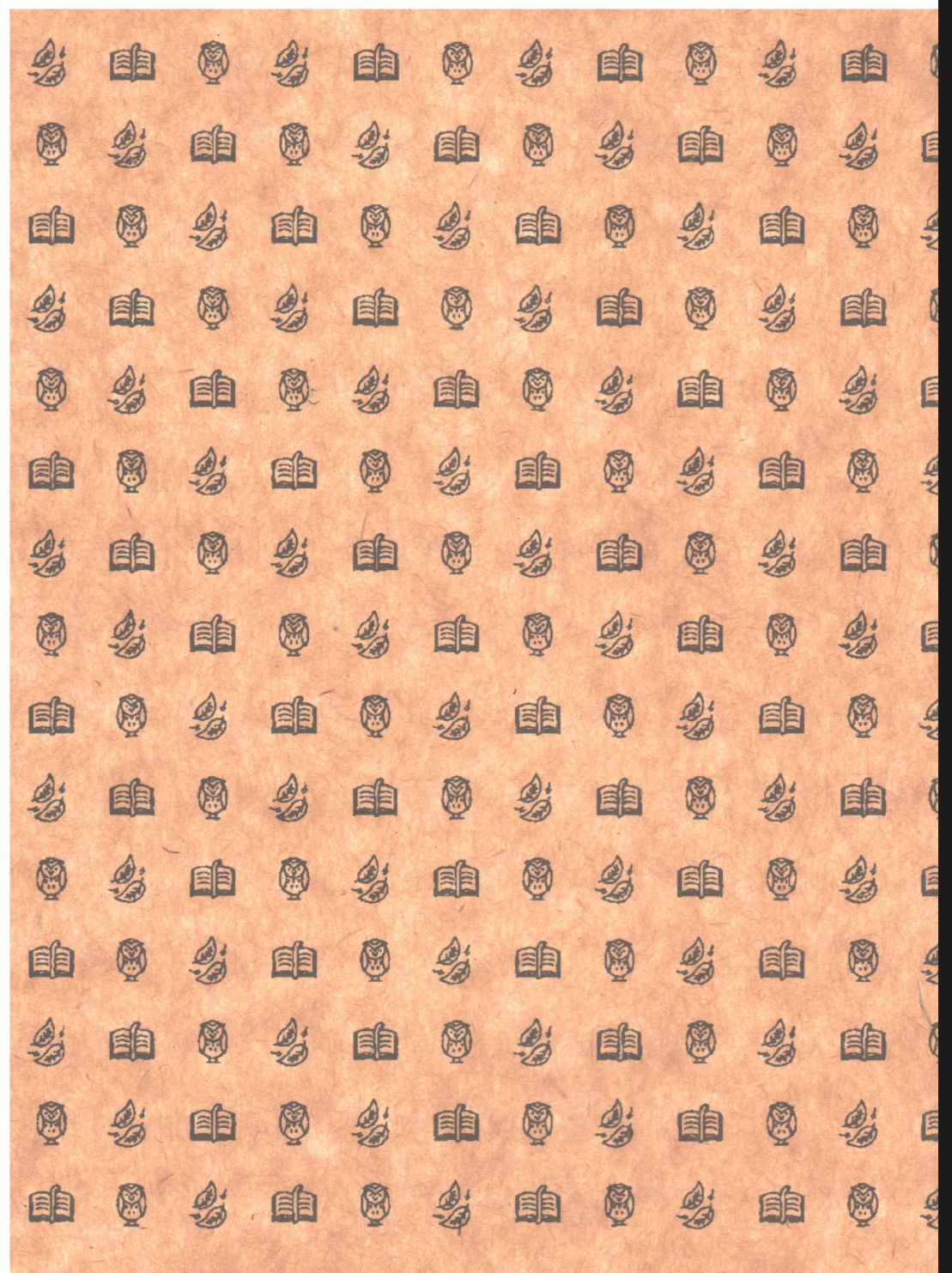


Tales of
New Orleans
and Southern Louisiana

QUENTIN PURVIS





Syl,
I can feel the shadows
circling. If something
happens... make some noise.
this will get you started.

-Celestine

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New Orleans
and Southern Louisiana



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Author's Foreword

As a native son of Orleans Parish, I left the *réconfort* of my belle Louisiane but once.

Carrying backpack and rifle, I journeyed with my fellow soldiers to the faraway South Pacific, a land as different from my home as night from day. Sharing C-rations and hand-rolled cigarettes during the endless watch, I often regaled my new companions with the folklore of my New Orleans childhood: spirits and figures that still float on the Mississippi River breeze, granting those who know them a *joie-de-vivre* as natural as sunshine.

I told these stories during the darkest wolf-hours—when snipers waited and bombs dropped—but despite their burdens, my platoon brothers listened with wonder. These tales were a beating heart for us, and a beacon that guided me back home.

Upon my return, I assembled this collection, eager to share my Louisiana legends with the rest of the world. May these stories enthrall you and free you from your cares, just as they did my brothers-in-arms.

Quentin Purvis

Marigny, New Orleans, 1947

The Rougarou



Cajuns speak in whispers of the Rougarou, who slinks through the swamps of Louisiana in the night. Appearing as a furred man with the head of a wolf, its image has existed in many cultures for centuries, including medieval French legends of the "loup-garou" or "wolf-man." But while the story may be old, sightings have continued up until today. In fact, I have my suspicions that the one below might be based on a distant relative of mine, Clayton Devereaux, who fought on the Western Front during the Great War. —QP

Many years ago, a soldier once returned from war to his home on the banks of the Atchafalaya River. Now a shadow of himself, the man became prone to fits of melancholy, much to the anguish of his poor wife and their two sons.

One evening, the man seemed in a particularly dark mood. With wild eyes, he confessed to his wife a string of horrors he had committed during the war. The most shocking of these had been the murder of a farmer's entire family for three loaves of bread and a pound of freshly-churned butter. This, he said, was the source of all his woe. On that fateful night, the old grand-mère of this family had locked herself in the attic when the man attacked. Using straw and spit and her own blood, she'd called on an older power to hex the starving soldier.

"I've been carrying her curse ever since," the man mumbled as his wife clutched his hand in fright.

The wife asked softly, "Of what curse do you speak?" But in her heart, she needed no answer. She knew the curse of the Rougarou—and likewise she knew its remedy. The accursed need but wait one hundred and one days, at which point the poor wretch would be able to transfer his affliction by exchange of blood with a willing recipient. Although she knew his time was near, she never dreamed the remedy he would pursue.

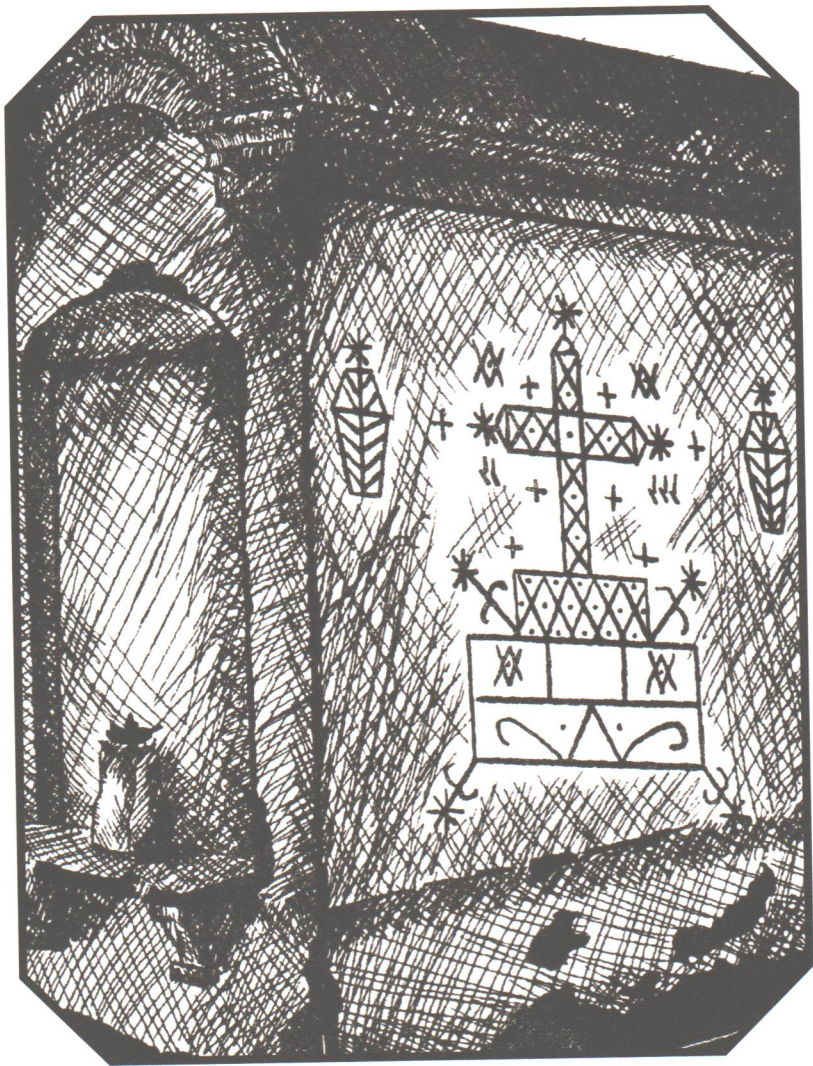
Two nights later, she awoke with a start to the sounds of whispers. Tiptoeing across the creaky floorboards, she followed the sound to their children's room. When she opened the door, she discovered the man kneeling by the eldest boy's bedside, his hands clasped as if in prayer.

"Take this burden from me, my child," he cried. "Let your poor father exist as a natural man once again." The wife gasped in terror. The man spun around to face her, framed by the moon, his eyes glowing red. He snarled and pushed past her, running through the house, out the door, and into the wild, green landscape of Acadiana.

The wife gave chase, calling after him, but the man disappeared from sight along the riverbank. Days later, she and some neighbors found various pieces of his sweat-soaked clothes, collecting them one at a time like wildflowers.

Search as they might—and they did for years—the man was nowhere to be found. To this day, he has yet to return. Still, some say if you listen very closely, you can still hear his cries echo across the river. On their honor, they attest that ne'er a more haunting sound was heard.

Graveyard Guardians



Thomas Gray Tully, whom I call father-in-law, worked as a mortician for many years in Gloucestershire before moving his young family to New Orleans. Here he continued to tend to the bodies of the recently dead and prepare them for their final resting places in local cemeteries. He was well acquainted with the guardians of the cemetery, and I am indebted to him for his knowledge. —QP

Once there was an old cemetery caretaker who had grown too white-haired and weary to continue with his work. He gave the keys of the graveyard to his son with this warning: "As you go about your labors, never forget the Guardians."

The son gave his father a suspicious look, and the father wagged his finger.

"You must heed my advice," he said. "First, there is the *loa* Baron Samedi, the leader of the Guédé. Wearing a tall black hat, he appears smoking cigarillos and loudly eating roasted peanuts, his favorite of the offerings given to him. Some call him by another name: Saint Expedite. But to me, he is always Samedi." The father drew the sign of Baron Samedi on a piece of paper and handed it to his son.

"As you'll see from his sigil with its two coffins," the father said, "he represents the gates that separate the living and the dead. Samedi lords over all aspects of death and burial, so you must always pay your respects, both to him and to his saintly counterpart. Do you understand?"

Much to the father's dismay, his son laughed. "What utter pish posh for children!" he said.

The father shook his head sadly. "You will soon learn, my son, for Samedi appears to those who show derision to him or his wife."

Again, the son laughed. "And now this Samedi, he has a wife as well? An honest married spirit?"

"Samedi's wife is Maman Brigitte," the father explained. "Ruling by Samedi's side and especially protective of the spirits of women, Maman Brigitte demands offerings of pepper-infused rum in exchange for guarding graves and tombstones."

Thinking his father a doddering old man, the son arrived at the cemetery that night empty-handed. By the dim light of his lantern, he made his way through the tombs and vaults, no sound to be heard but his own footsteps.

"Baron Samedi and Maman Brigitte," he muttered to himself. "What utter nonsense!"

It was then that he heard it. A crunch, crunch, crunch, like the chewing of peanuts, followed by the smell of smoke. It was faint at first, but then it grew closer and closer—until it seemed it was coming from over his shoulder.

"Impossible," the son whispered to no one in particular.

"Is it?" said a booming voice behind him.

The next morning, they found the young man lying by one of the tombs, having swooned from fright at the sound. Babbling, he was taken back to his father's house, where the old man merely shook his head.

The next day, the son arrived promptly for his rounds, his pockets overflowing with peanuts, cigarillos, and pepper-infused rum. And to this day, at least as I hear it, he's arrived at his post that way ever since.

Mère Petitpas and Her Violet Absinthe



No one knew from whence Mère Petitpas or her purple libation came: My cousin Apollon always said she was a witch who crept into town from a lair deep in the Henderson Swamp; others claimed she was an itinerant healer from across the sea who arrived in New Orleans by boat.

There were records of sea shanties sung about a "purple sorcière from Nouvelle-Orléans" dating as far back as 1734, but the last known sighting of Mère Petitpas occurred in 1903, when her photograph was taken by Henri Milner with his daguerreotype. While Henri was trampled by a runaway horse later that week, and Mère Petitpas was never seen in New Orleans again, Milner's portrait of her passed through the hands of antique collectors for decades before it was lost forever. —QP

In the old days, every soul in New Orleans knew Mère Petitpas—not just by sight but by sound. The folks on Frenchmen Street would stop in their tracks when they heard the strange jing-jing of her dented old bell: pointed in shape it was, as if she had plucked it from some Far Eastern temple. Music would pause in mid-song, all conversing would cease, unruly children would be shushed—for Mère Petitpas and her purple miracle were a-coming.

All would hold their breath until they caught sight of her, dressed in a simple frock, her wild hair hanging loosely about her like a cloak. She always walked ahead of her horse, a gray old beast with thick clumps of bayou mud drying on its giant hooves. As ancient as the lady herself, the horse dutifully pulled her Chariot des Merveilles—or as you or I might call it, her wagon of miracles.

What was inside her Chariot that held the full attention of Frenchmen Street? Bottles she made and the violet spirit they contained: "la Spirale Violette," part absinthe, part mystical brew. Deep purple in color from its secret ingredient, the Datura—known to many as moonflower or jimsonweed—it cost a king's ransom. Those who partook of this violet absinthe's charms found themselves in another realm and, when they awoke from their haze, insisted the drink had levitated them into the spirit world. Mère Petitpas would come round but once every season with her new crop of bottles, and within minutes her cabinet would be emptied. Legend claims her visitations went on for over two centuries, though no one knows how such a feat could be possible.

But while her specter perhaps lived on, her violet absinthe did not. As the years passed, nearly every bottle of her mystical brew was imbibed—for what collector could resist the temptation to taste its rapturous gifts? In time, only one remained intact. The whispers say the remaining bottle is hidden somewhere in New Orleans. Whether it be found in a dusty attic, forgotten trunk, or cabinet of curiosities, there the violet absinthe sits—waiting for a brave soul to open the bottle and surrender to its otherworldly charms.

Grave of the Voodoo Queen



Buried amongst the sun baked crypts of St. Louis Cemetery No. 1, in a once crimson monument now spotted with peeling whitewash, are the bones of Marie Laveau. Laveau was one of the most famous Voodoo practitioners in New Orleans history, and while many sought her help during her life, multitudes more have sought it after her death.

Incidentally, those with a less spiritual perspective believe Laveau gained influence over her clientele through her job as a hairdresser, which gave her intimate knowledge of the gossip in town. She understood how loose guarded tongues can be when they're being pampered, and the secrets she learned became integral to her work. —QP

Once there was a woman who held the city of New Orleans in the palm of her hand. Gifted with powers unseen in a generation, she drew thousands to her rituals, from Congo Square to the banks of the churning lake overlooking the city. No one who saw her standing before the masses, turban upon her head and boa constrictor draped across her shoulders, ever questioned her title: Voodoo Queen. Her true name, however, was Marie Laveau.

All manner of men, from bankers to ditch diggers, sought her counsel. It was said she possessed mystical abilities so great they could bring the ailing back from the brink of death or cause the noose to vanish from around the condemned man's neck. Even after her demise, those who required her guidance could not abandon their source of wisdom. As the years passed, her grave became a beacon for those who sought her intercession from the other side.

Even to this day, some say if you desire a favor of the Voodoo Queen, you need only ask. Coins, flowers, and candles will provide a suitable offering, and an X marked on her tomb will provide a witness to others that Marie keeps her promises.

Those who wish to hasten her favors often look to a saint to aid their request. Steps away on Basin Street stands a Catholic church that contains a statue of Saint Expedite, who is said by Laveau's followers to be one and the same with Baron Samedi—for in Louisiana Voodoo, every *loa* conceals itself inside a saint, and every saint conceals itself inside a *loa*. In addition to Laveau's grave, supplicants often visit the statue of Saint Expedite, who is said to bring any wish made to Laveau to quick fruition, just as his name suggests.

The Pirate Brothers Lafitte and the Baratarians



Many conflicting accounts exist of these two men. Regardless, their exploits on the turquoise seas of the New World are the stuff of legend: Were they charlatans? Pirates? Freedom fighters? Entrepreneurs? Some or none of these may be true, but it is known that two Lafitte brothers came to New Orleans in the early 1800s and worked together for a time as smugglers. The rest is delightful speculation. —QP

Between the bustling city of New Orleans and the Gulf of Mexico, there is a land called Barataria. Covered in dense swamps and winding waterways, this place was once a smuggler's paradise. Those who brought their spoils into safe harbor there called themselves the Baratarians, and their leaders were the pirate brothers Jean and Pierre.

Pierre Lafitte first arrived in the New World during the reign of Napoleon, eager to make his fortune. Not long after, his mysterious brother Jean followed in his footsteps and, together, they began smuggling goods through the port of *La Nouvelle-Orléans*. However, one fateful day, fleeing the consequences of their crimes, they withdrew into the Baratarian swamps. From there, they sailed throughout the Gulf of Mexico, seizing ships and returning their plunder to their safe haven deep within the heart of Louisiana.

Many times, the law of the land attempted to bring its weight down upon the brothers. However, once the pursuers were drawn into the mysterious waters that criss-crossed the Lafittes' hideaway, the pirates had the upper hand. Anyone who sought the brothers in their own territory lived to regret their folly.

However, their enterprise could not last forever. When war came, the Baratarians changed their allegiances and fought to keep their homeland safe. They were granted a full pardon for their former crimes, and many of them retreated to the land they loved, vowing to live an honest life henceforth. They stayed for generations, and many believe the Baratarians' descendants still live along the swamps and bayous that carried their forebears' ships to safety.

As for the pirate brothers themselves, their end was less peaceable than that of their comrades. Both Jean and Pierre were killed by Spanish soldiers as they attempted to ply their trade far from their home of Louisiana. But even though they met their ends miles from the waters of Barataria, some say that on a dark night, under a full moon, you can still hear the sounds of their ships gliding through the waters of the bayou. For once a pirate, always a pirate—even in death.